

Farming

For thousands of years, our ancestors were hunter-gatherers, constantly roaming the land to hunt animals and collect wild plants for food. Around 12,000 years ago, people in the Middle East began to live in settled farming communities. This settling-down process was known as the “Agricultural Revolution,” and it gave people a more certain supply of food. By 500 BCE, agriculture had spread across most of the world.



BETTER CROPS

Ancient farmers found out that by planting only the largest and best wild species they could gradually improve their crops, a system known as domestication. In the Middle East, people grew wheat or barley developed from wild grasses. In the Americas, the most important crop was maize (corn), which was domesticated by 7000 BCE.

◀ PRIMITIVE TO MODERN

The primitive type of corn (left) was developed to become the much bigger modern corn (right).



THE FERTILE CRESCENT

The first farmers lived in the region of Mesopotamia in modern-day southern Iraq. This was located between two rivers—the Tigris and the Euphrates—where crops grew well in the rich soil and domesticated animals thrived. By 9000 BCE, farming had spread across the Middle East in a crescent-shaped area that reached into Egypt.

HARROW

One of the first important farming inventions was the harrow. This rakelike tool was used after plowing to break up the soil and smooth out the surface. It made planting crops easier. The first harrows were made of wood, but later, iron was used.

